Subject & Predication Codebook

Note: subject and predication scheme originally also coded emotions and hyperbole, hence the name visual register. branding_only is the old name from when it was coded, called minimal+repetitive in the thesis. Kept as branding_only here so it matches the spreadsheets (too many dependent links to change it there).

Overview

The unit is one post, i.e. everything the audience sees, so every image of a carousel or the whole video. Anything flagged branding_only = 1 isn't coded. Everything else is, reposts included.

Each post coded in max of three slots. Each slot has a subject (who/what), a predication (how the image treats them) and subject_AI (TRUE/FALSE, blank if the slot's empty). Written as subject / predication, e.g. own_leader / none.

Slots

- Each different combination of subject, treatment and real/generated gets its own slot, so similar figures share one. Three MPs speaking are one party_politician / none slot, but the leader next to them gets their own. Usually one or two slots per post.
- If there's more than three, keep the first three in slot order. If it's leader + party_politician, drop the latter
- If treatment is mixed/contradictory, go with the dominant one. Exception is generated parts of AI items and speeches, judged as a whole

Basic criteria

- General metric: the picture decides. Basically "what is this a picture of?"
- Text can tell you who/what is shown and why, but can't add a judgement the picture doesn't make. Generated images are coded the same way, subject_AI is the only difference. *Note. This is a split of both depiction/framing, made before they were defined in the thesis.*

Nothing depicted, no subject

- Text cards, logos, quotes, charts, infographics, icons etc. are coded none.
- A photo/drawing on a text card only counts if it shows something nameable and takes up a decent chunk of the card (roughly a quarter or more), or is the only image.
- Screenshots, billboards and screens are coded for the picture in them. Avatars/thumbnails ignored

Coding materials

- **AI note:** which elements are generated or real (timestamps for videos). subject_AI comes from this, but it doesn't decide subject/treatment and isn't post text.
- **POSSIBLE duplicate line:** just a prompt to check if duped for consistency, sometimes template cards get flagged despite diff words - from videoduplicatefinder and imagededup.

Subject Kinds

Kind	Includes	Coded elsewhere
own_leader The posting party's leader	party leader at the time of posting, generated/real, incl. on opponents' posters and in news photos	• Other party figures (party_politician)
party_politician The posting party's other politicians	current/historic own figures other than the leader (e.g. co-leaders, officials, spokespeople, candidates, MPs, MEPs, councillors), on a leader's account, that leader's party figures, incl. on opponents' posters and in news photos	• Allies, departed members, non-member ministers, parliamentary officers (politician) • Anonymous activists (individual) • Supporter crowds (mass) • Family, no slot
politician Other identifiable public figures	any identifiable real public figure, past/present, not the party's own, opponents, EU officials, foreign leaders, historical politicians, recognisable journalists, celebrities, athletes, clergy, academics, influencers	• Private persons in the news, unnamed officials (individual) • Historical, religious or fictional figures like Joan of Arc (individual/mass)
individual One to about nine people	e.g. a worker, a family of four, a veiled woman, a named private person, part of a person (e.g. a hand), generated people	• ~ten or more, or mostly indistinct (mass)
mass Crowds and large groups	ten or more, or mostly indistinct (e.g. rally crowd, prayer rows, vigil, riot-police lines), out-group men in a queue, column or boatload, any number	• When several faces are clearly visible/distinct cut-off ~nine people
institution An institution or its stand-in	parliaments, courts, ministries, EU buildings, flag/map as the main image, personified institutions (e.g. Lady Justice), things labelled as an institution (e.g. a crane labelled PSOE), rival logo/name acted upon, uniformed enforcers of a menacing state	• Police/soldiers on duty (individual or mass) • Building behind people, not a subject • Identifiable people keep their own kind
economy Livelihoods	business, industry or livelihood shown through premises or products (e.g. factory, farm, shop, port, closing-down window)	• A single product standing for itself (object)

Kind	Includes	Coded elsewhere
place Cities, homes, land, buildings	city, street, home, landmark, landscape, border, territory or map, places of worship, asylum hotels and reception centres	• Background scenery, not a subject
object Things standing for themselves	weapons, vehicles, food, animals, products, money, documents, memorial candles and flowers, national flag shown for itself	• Held or worn (prop, no slot)
none	slot 1 only, when nothing is depicted	

Predication Values

none is the default, every other value needs a visible cue. Drawn, comic, 3-D or painterly style isn't a cue

Value	Meaning	Typical picture cues
none	No evaluative treatment	portrait, talking head, speech, debate, street, building, product shot, ordinary snapshot or news photo
menace	A danger	weapons in use or aimed, aggression, attack, intimidating stance, mass arrival, machine wrecking something
othering	Alien, not belonging, no harm shown	veils in a Western street, prayer rows
ridicule	Absurd, undignified, weak	caricature, clown make-up, crown and selfie, figure boxing himself, nesting dolls, gag injury on an edited opponent
blame	Author/beneficiary of a harm	beside a harm or its victims, e.g. leaders before missiles or a burning city, red X across a face, crossed-out opponents, luxury beside the poor
victim	Suffering, endangered, ruined or lost, shown for sympathy	any kind of subject, e.g. a pensioner at a bin, a woman attacked, a derelict plant, attack site afterwards, memorial candles, grieving vigil, dog in distress
heroic	Strong, decisive, admirable (needs a staging cue)	victory sign/raised fist, speech before a cheering crowd, heroic portrait, ceremony/parade, non-human subjects with grandeur/struggle, e.g. dramatic sky, low angle, monumental scale, flag in a strong wind
wholesome	Decent, warm, innocent, idealised	hugs, laughter, idealised family or worker, animals, non-human subjects in peace/abundance, e.g. the promised villa, Italian food, idealised = visibly staged (golden light, spotless setting, 'synthetically' happiness)

Decision Rulings

1. **The picture sets the direction, text identifies.** Text can tip between similar values, e.g. rusted cars captioned as a plant closure is economy / victim, but it can't add a judgement on its own. A smiling mother and child under a child-benefit caption is still individual / wholesome. Spoken text counts as text too.
2. **Real victims.** If the post says a real person was killed/attacked/abused, they're victim even in an ordinary photo. Doesn't apply to anonymous or generated figures, groups, natural deaths or perpetrators.
3. **Own people (own_leader and party_politician): none unless staged.**
   - **Heroic portrait:** needs at least two of low angle, dramatic lighting, distant gaze, flags blowing, painted style. Flat backgrounds, headshots and cut-outs stay none.
   - **Speech:** only heroic if there's a cheering crowd. A seated audience is just listening.
   - **Other heroic cues:** victory sign, raised fist, ceremonial role, statesmanlike signing, uniform/armour.
   - **Wholesome:** needs genuine warmth, like hugs, laughter, holding a child/animal, being mobbed by supporters, sharing food.
   - Anything else is none. A smile, wave or handshake isn't enough on its own.
   - Supporters pictured with an own figure get the same tests, but only get a slot in their own shot. Real victim and opponent rules still apply.
4. **Opponents: no evaluation without a picture cue.** Neutral or unflattering photos that haven't been edited are none, however hostile the caption is. Cues are things like crosses, stamps, drawn-on features, distortion, caricature, harm in frame, mocking scenes. Words/emojis next to a face don't count, and neither does colour treatment (greyscale, red border etc.).
5. **When values compete.**
   - If they're causing the harm it's menace, if they're beside it (blamed/profiting) it's blame.
   - Crowns, thrones and luxury with no harm are ridicule if absurd, otherwise none
   - Heroic beats wholesome, and if parts are tied an evaluative value beats none.
6. **Out-group men.** Out-group meaning presented as migrants, asylum seekers, foreigners or Muslims, going off setting, dress, worship or text (never just skin colour). In order:
   a. Worship is othering, any number.
   b. Arriving/confronting in formation (queue, column, boatload) is mass / menace, any number.
   c. Idle is othering (individual up to about nine, mass above that).
   d. One to three aggressive/armed is individual / menace.

   Mixed groups coded as men if mostly men, otherwise as women and children. If distress is the focus it's victim, but a distant overcrowded boat stays menace.

7. **Out-group women, children, dress and worship.** Out of place (e.g. veils in a Western street) is othering, never wholesome. Weapons/aggression is menace, suffering is victim. A mosque shown as foreign is place / othering.
8. **Uniformed figures.** Only institution when they're the faceless arm of a menacing state (masked, generated, using force on civilians), and not just because the text says so. Otherwise they're people and coded on treatment, so on duty is none, parade heroic, helping wholesome, hurt victim. Someone being arrested is a separate subject.
1. **Insects as food.** Always object / menace. Someone eating them is victim if distressed, ridicule if they're enjoying it.
2. **Armed opponents.** Ridicule if there's no combat, menace if attacking, blame if beside war damage. An unedited inspection photo is none.
3. **Subjects in videos, carousels and composites.**
    - **Screen time:** real footage needs about 3 seconds on screen in total, or two or more shots. Listeners/interviewers only if singled out, speaking opponents always.
    - **Crowds:** cutaways of about 3 seconds or a third of a still (not just behind a speaker) count as mass, coded on what they're doing.
    - **Generated content:** every recognisable generated subject on AI items counts, however brief. If a person appears both real and generated and they're treated differently, that's two slots.
    - **Branding:** recurring opening/closing cards aren't subjects unless they're the whole post.
    - **Composites:** a pasted-in real person is coded as that person. Generated scenes only if notable (e.g. missiles), not just scenery.
    - **Props:** anything held/worn doesn't get a slot. Generated images on billboards or screens in the post are coded for what they show.
4. **Slot order.** On AI items generated subjects go first, then the dominant subject. Otherwise just reading order (left to right, tile order, order of appearance).
5. **subject_AI.**
    - **TRUE:** generated subjects, incl. AI likenesses and subjects added into real photos.
    - **FALSE:** photos and footage, incl. a real face on a generated body (e.g. Scholz on the throne) and AI-animated/retouched photos.
    - If unsure whether it's photographed or rendered, FALSE
    - Conventional items are FALSE throughout, mark unsure if anything looks generated.
    - Blank when the slot is empty.

Edge Cases

- Satire carried only by words over a neutral picture is politician / none (the words go to the Policy Topics Codebook).
- A murdered/attacked person shown alive (e.g. a selfie of a real crime victim) is individual / victim, or politician / victim for a murdered public figure. !!Only case where text completes the predication.

- Small groups are individual, one slot if treated alike.
- Riot-police lines being pushed by protesters are mass / victim, not institution - framing
- A real face on a generated body (e.g. combat helmet, superhero suit) is coded as the person, subject_AI FALSE. So the item might not have a TRUE slot. *Note: seems slightly unintuitive, but works out roughly correct in spreadsheet when weighted across slots*

Own People (own_leader and party_politician)

The leader named with each account is own_leader. Party politicians list isn't exhaustive, any other official, candidate, MP/MEP of the party counts.

Account and leader (own_leader)	Party politicians (party_politician)
AU One Nation, Pauline Hanson	One Nation senators and candidates
BE Vlaams Belang, Tom Van Grieken	Gerolf Annemans, Chris Janssens and VB candidates
DE AfD, Alice Weidel	Tino Chrupalla, Maximilian Krah, René Aust and AfD candidates
DK Dansk Folkeparti, Morten Messerschmidt	Anders Vistisen and DF candidates
ES VOX, Santiago Abascal	Jorge Buxadé (Rat man), Ignacio Garriga, Pepa Millán, Rocío de Meer and VOX candidates
FR Rassemblement National, Jordan Bardella	Marine Le Pen and RN candidates
IT Lega, Matteo Salvini	Roberto Vannacci (2024 candidate) and Lega candidates
NL PVV, Geert Wilders	PVV MPs and candidates
UK Reform UK, Nigel Farage (Richard Tice until 3 June 2024)	Lee Anderson, Richard Tice (from 3 June 2024) and Reform candidates

Discrepancies/Exceptions

- **Co-leaders:** Marine Le Pen (RN) and Tino Chrupalla (AfD) are party_politician. Leader is whoever's behind the paired leader account, i.e. Jordan Bardella and Alice Weidel.
- **Change of leader:** Richard Tice led Reform UK until 3 June 2024, so he's own_leader on posts before then and party_politician after. Farage is own_leader throughout, incl. on his own account before 3 June.
- **Unnamed party figures (e.g. social media manager) count as party_politician.**
- **Slot limit:** if there's four subjects (rare, only seen with leader+party_politician) the leader keeps theirs and the party_politician slot is dropped
- **Small insets aren't subjects, e.g. Vannacci thumbnails next to a big Salvini cut-out.**